ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Why Do We Wear Sisit?

Derech Hashem 4:6:3-6

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 6, paragraphs 3-6 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 7 March 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Rising out of the night (paragraph 3)

The Rabbi recalled the last class: God created day and night because there must be light and darkness, each with its time to dominate. At night darkness and evil rule, impurity descends on a sleeping person, and sleep is a taste of death.

How do we get out of this each morning? The Ramhal says God prepared ways for a person to rise from where he descended at night, and not only the individual: humanity as a whole is to be uplifted and enlightened every morning. For this, certain words and actions were established, which the following paragraphs explain.

Washing the hands (paragraph 4)

The first is netilat yadayim, because the hands are where the impurity rested. God decreed that washing them correctly, alternating the hands as the Kabbalah teaches, purifies the entire body. "This tells you something": someone who does not wash in the morning is not only impure on his hands but in his whole body. The impurity rests on the extremities but spreads across the body, and washing removes it. It also rectifies the darkness of the night in the world at large.

To this Hazal added cleaning the body in the morning by relieving oneself. The Gemara in Berakhot says that someone who relieves himself, washes his hands, puts on tefillin and prays is as if he built an altar. The Rabbi noted that the Rambam rules one should get into the habit of relieving oneself properly in the morning and at night. "It's not easy." The custom of going to the mikveh in the morning comes from the same idea.

Is anyone really pure?

A participant asked how washing only the hands can clear the impurity from everywhere, including the feet. The Rabbi recalled the Ben Ish Hai from last class: the impurity on the feet is too much to remove this way, which is why the kohanim washed their feet too. And in any case none of us is fully pure today: without the ashes of the red heifer, everyone has touched someone who has touched a dead body.

"I think it's more symbolic." Every morning we wash and remind ourselves: I was asleep, I lost my neshamah, I am back, ready for a new and pure day, to regain the light over the darkness. Is it just hygiene? "For the Ramhal it's more than hygiene." A participant called it spiritual hygiene, and discipline, and the Rabbi agreed.

Two more misvot (paragraph 5)

Two further misvot from the 613 help complete the daily service: sisit and tefillin. The Ramhal first explains each one, then how they fit into getting rid of the darkness of the night. This class covered sisit; tefillin follows next time.

Sisit: holiness in everything (paragraph 6)

The Rabbi asked the group why we wear sisit. Answers included the gematria reminding us of the 613 misvot, a sign, and accepting the yoke of Hashem.

The Ramhal gives two reasons. First, God wanted us to be sanctified in everything we do, so He gave us misvot in every situation. Build a house, put up a parapet. Put up a door, put up a mezuzah. Buy clothes, check for shaatnez. Plough a field, do not yoke two kinds of animals together. "People complain about it... that's the point." Every part of life is infused with holiness: a blessing before eating, a blessing after the bathroom. Our clothes are part of us too, so they also need holiness, and God commanded sisit on them.

Sisit: the servant's uniform

The deeper reason is the one a participant had suggested. "Sorry to put it so crudely": a dog's collar shows whose it is, and sisit are our collar. They show that we are servants of God and accept the yoke of Heaven.

The Ramhal explains why this matters. We have the power to rectify the world through our actions, as learned in Part 1. But all of that rests on one foundation: that the person is a servant of the Almighty. Serving someone who never asked you to serve is not the same. First you identify as a servant, then your service has its effect.

The Rabbi's illustration was the changing of the guard at the palace. If he turned up in a suit and tie and wanted to take part, he would be told: first put on the uniform, the hat and the red cloak, and then, done properly, the Queen will be pleased with you. "So too, before we do the misvot, first identify as a servant."

He stressed not to confuse this with the kippah. The kippah is a custom, a sign of recognising that there is something higher than you, rather than a halachic requirement or a mark of identity. "In essence, how you identify as a Jew is your sisit," even when they are tucked in. "It's for yourself."

Sisit at prayer

The misvah of sisit applies whenever one wears a four-cornered garment, at any time of day. But Hazal added that even someone not wearing one should put one on for prayer, so that at least once each morning a person accepts the yoke and identifies as a servant taking part in

the work of rectifying the world. "This is really beautiful." Identifying as a servant is far more powerful than serving without it, and this is how sisit help remove the darkness of the night.

On the gematria (600 plus eight threads and five knots making 613), the Rabbi said it is a lovely idea but not the plain meaning, since halachically one knot is enough. The plain meaning, as Rashi says, is that sisit remind you of Heaven and of whose servant you are, and the blue of the tekhelet recalls the sky. He ended with the well-known story of the man who travelled to a distant harlot, and at the last moment his sisit struck him in the face and he turned back: "I'm a servant. How can I be doing this? That's the power of sisit."

Summary

- Each morning God gave us ways to rise out of the night's darkness, for ourselves and for the world.
- Washing the hands in the alternating way removes the impurity from the whole body; for the Ramhal it is more than hygiene.
- Sisit bring holiness to our clothes, as other misvot bring it to our homes, food and fields.
- More deeply, sisit are the servant's uniform: our power to rectify the world rests on first identifying as God's servants.
- That is why sisit are worn at prayer even by someone without a four-cornered garment.

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